

THE UNIVERSAL HOUSE OF JUSTICE

Riḍván 2014

To the Bahá'ís of Egypt

Dearly loved Friends,

With immense happiness we extend our loving greetings to you on this long-awaited occasion: the restoration of the National Spiritual Assembly of the Bahá'ís of Egypt after the lapse of more than a half-century. As recent events unfolded in your country, it became increasingly apparent that the informal arrangements in place over the last few decades would no longer be adequate for managing your affairs and channelling your energies towards the betterment of society. It is fitting then that a more formal structure emerge, notwithstanding that official registration cannot be contemplated. Every follower of the Greatest Name will rejoice at this re-emergence of administrative institutions in one of the most venerable Bahá'í communities in the world. We are confident that many of your compatriots who have shown their commitment to a diverse and tolerant society will share your gladness at this historic juncture.

Established during the ministry of Bahá'u'lláh, your community owes its origin to the arrival of two pioneers, who took up their residence in Egypt in 1868. That same year, your country was honoured beyond measure by the presence of the Ancient Beauty at its shores, when His steamer docked in Alexandria for two days before He and His company of exiles changed ship and set sail for Port Said en route to 'Akká. In your precious land, some of the Faith's earliest Arab adherents and admirers were raised and many notable believers contributed to its rapid growth. The establishment of new centres, as well as the creation of the Bahá'í agency in Alexandria founded for the purpose of the dispatch and distribution of Bahá'u'lláh's correspondence, was yet another feat of your spiritual forebears.

Four decades after its inception, your community was blessed by the visits of 'Abdu'l-Bahá, which occurred between 1910 and 1913 and are a highlight of your brilliant legacy. During these monumental visits, the Master conversed with Egyptians from all walks of life, infusing souls with the warmth of His love and enlightening minds with values and principles essential, as much now as they were then, for the building of a peaceful and progressive society. Inspired by the example of 'Abdu'l-Bahá, the Egyptian Bahá'ís from their earliest days courageously upheld the divine teachings in their individual and collective lives, forming their National Spiritual Assembly in 1924, the first on the African continent and in the Arab region, at a time when there were only three other such institutions in the world. It was in your country that a verdict of a religious court, subsequently upheld by the highest ecclesiastical authorities in Cairo, declared the Faith as a new and independent religion, a declaration hailed by Shoghi Effendi as "the first historic step ... on the road leading to its ultimate and world-wide recognition".

Despite a history marked by periods of persecution, the valiant Egyptian believers have withstood their manifold trials with fortitude and kept the flame of faith burning bright. We are moved to express our deep admiration for your heroism and steadfastness in the face of adversity, a testimony to the love you hold in your hearts for the Abhá Beauty. Our profound gratitude is also offered to those many friends who guided and supported your

activities in the course of many critical years, and whose endeavours were fortified by the institution of the Counsellors.

Notwithstanding the obstacles in your path, you continue to contribute to the betterment of modern Egyptian society, and you offer your share to the discourse concerning its future out of love for and loyalty to your homeland. These qualities were greatly in evidence in the determined dissemination of the open letter addressed to your fellow Egyptians and the profound conversations in many social spaces to which it gave rise. It is clear that your well-wishers and many like-minded souls amongst your fellow citizens have recognized the sincerity of your desire to serve humankind and that you seek nothing but advancement for your country and its true prosperity. Indeed, the people of Egypt, heirs to a great civilization, are sure to appreciate the society-building power inherent in the Teachings and the lofty spiritual values they enshrine.

At this auspicious time, your priority will be to pursue those endeavours aimed at nurturing capacity for service and fostering strong and vibrant communities. May you include more and more souls in the fold of those activities at the heart of a flourishing and meaningful pattern of collective life, infused with the spirit of the Creative Word. May you seek every opportunity to involve those, particularly from the younger generations, who are longing to shed the lethargy induced by negative social forces and contribute to processes that promote the material and spiritual well-being of their people. No more beneficial service than this can be imagined.

How befitting then that at this significant period in the evolution of your society and after decades spent in the absence of elected institutions, you once again have all the instruments that can aid you to fulfil your highest aspiration of service and make a constructive contribution to the development of your nation. It behooves the members of these Assemblies to approach their sacred tasks with extreme humility and self-effacement; sacrifice their own likes and dislikes as well as their personal interests; banish from their deliberations any form of prejudice; consult not only among themselves, but as much as possible with the friends; attend to the needs of young and old, families and individuals, veteran and new believers; and adopt such measures as are conducive to the progress and welfare of the community. For their part, the believers should demonstrate their love for these precious institutions, pray for their success, cooperate wholeheartedly with them, support their plans, and embrace in unity their decisions.

Beloved friends: you will now have the bounty of turning to your local and national bodies for their sustaining support. Recall these words of the Master:

These Spiritual Assemblies are aided by the Spirit of God. Their defender is ‘Abdu’l-Bahá. Over them He spreadeth His wings. What bounty is there greater than this? These Spiritual Assemblies are shining lamps and heavenly gardens, from which the fragrances of holiness are diffused over all regions, and the lights of knowledge are shed abroad over all created things. From them the spirit of life streameth in every direction. They, indeed, are the potent sources of the progress of man, at all times and under all conditions.

Our ardent supplications at the Holy Threshold are offered on your behalf, that you may be confirmed in your noble endeavours by the invigorating breezes of the All-Merciful wafting from the Abhá Kingdom.

[signed: The Universal House of Justice]